

Future Livability and Investment Report

Bottom Line

- Best balanced place to live in the current prototype: South Portland.
- Best broad investor/opportunity screen: Gorham.
- Best urban/career and car-light living play: Portland, especially where access gaps and zero-car households overlap.
- Best next-wave value-add screen: Westbrook and Gorham, but for different reasons: Westbrook has transit-proximate bones; Gorham has larger infrastructure gaps.

This is a screening report, not financial advice. It ranks towns from the current Greater Portland prototype using transit access, walkability, ACS demographics, mobility need, income, and service gaps.

What Americans Usually Need From A Future-Proof Place

- Housing that remains affordable relative to income.
- Good access to jobs, education, healthcare, groceries, and daily services.
- Transportation choices beyond a private car.
- Safe walkable streets, especially for children, older adults, and disabled residents.
- Climate-aware growth, resilient infrastructure, and lower transportation emissions.
- Local services that match the population: childcare, clinics, senior services, trades, small business, and workforce supports.

Future Livability Ranking

Rank	Town	Future Livability	Access	800m Coverage	Median Income	Poverty	Zero-Car HH	Best-Fit Lane
1	South Portland	58.4	72.27	86.26%	\$86,838	6.94%	7.82%	balanced residential, commuter-friendly housing, and local services
2	Falmouth	54.48	52.13	46.33%	\$150,919	2.3%	5.09%	age-friendly housing, healthcare services, and premium suburban living
3	Portland	53.25	74.18	89.5%	\$79,540	11.21%	15.4%	urban mixed-use, car-light rentals, small business, and workforce services
4	Westbrook	45.69	64.44	80.45%	\$85,038	7.97%	6%	transit-proximate housing and main-street redevelopment
5	Scarborough	44.93	36.46	37.07%	\$133,558	4.39%	1.67%	age-friendly housing, healthcare services, and premium suburban living
6	Gorham	31.93	29.58	12.13%	\$112,312	3.71%	4.11%	value-add mobility, workforce housing, clinics, and town-center infrastructure

Why South Portland leads: it combines strong access, good coverage, relatively low mobility need, and enough service proximity to be resilient for households that want convenience without depending entirely on downtown Portland.

Investor / Opportunity Ranking

Rank	Town	Opportunity	Need Index	Coverage Gap	Age 65+	Disability	Opportunity Lane
1	Gorham	64.24	26.96	87.87%	17.49%	10.99%	value-add mobility, workforce housing, clinics, and town-center infrastructure
2	Scarborough	59.68	25.6	62.93%	24.73%	10.8%	age-friendly housing, healthcare services, and premium suburban living
3	Falmouth	44.77	20.79	53.67%	24.47%	8.51%	age-friendly housing, healthcare services, and premium suburban living
4	Portland	39.13	17.5	10.5%	16.87%	12.66%	urban mixed-use, car-light rentals, small business, and workforce services
5	Westbrook	27.35	17.98	19.55%	18.06%	12.09%	transit-proximate housing and main-street redevelopment
6	South Portland	22.39	16.37	13.74%	20.72%	13.24%	balanced residential, commuter-friendly housing, and local services

Why Gorham screens high for opportunity: the model finds a strong gap between current access and future need. That often points to infrastructure, housing, mobility, healthcare, or local-service opportunities.

What Each Town Is Missing

Falmouth

- Current lane: age-friendly housing, healthcare services, and premium suburban living.
- Biggest missing needs: stronger transit access or last-mile mobility, sidewalk connectivity and safer walk-to-stop routes, healthcare access, local clinics, or medical shuttle service, school/youth access and family-service proximity, age-friendly housing, healthcare access, and senior mobility.
- Signal: access score 52.13, mobility need 20.79, ACS population 12,755.

Gorham

- Current lane: value-add mobility, workforce housing, clinics, and town-center infrastructure.
- Biggest missing needs: stronger transit access or last-mile mobility, more usable transit service/frequency, sidewalk connectivity and safer walk-to-stop routes, healthcare access, local clinics, or medical shuttle service, school/youth access and family-service proximity, foundational access investment before dense growth.
- Signal: access score 29.58, mobility need 26.96, ACS population 18,300.

Portland

- Current lane: urban mixed-use, car-light rentals, small business, and workforce services.
- Biggest missing needs: school/youth access and family-service proximity, car-light housing and reliable non-car mobility, affordable/workforce housing and anti-displacement support, accessible housing, ADA routes, and paratransit coordination.
- Signal: access score 74.18, mobility need 17.5, ACS population 68,854.

Scarborough

- Current lane: age-friendly housing, healthcare services, and premium suburban living.
- Biggest missing needs: stronger transit access or last-mile mobility, more usable transit service/frequency, sidewalk connectivity and safer walk-to-stop routes, healthcare access, local clinics, or medical shuttle service, school/youth access and family-service proximity, age-friendly housing, healthcare access, and senior mobility, foundational access investment before dense growth.

- Signal: access score 36.46, mobility need 25.6, ACS population 23,215.

South Portland

- Current lane: balanced residential, commuter-friendly housing, and local services.
- Biggest missing needs: healthcare access, local clinics, or medical shuttle service, age-friendly housing, healthcare access, and senior mobility, accessible housing, ADA routes, and paratransit coordination.
- Signal: access score 72.27, mobility need 16.37, ACS population 26,930.

Westbrook

- Current lane: transit-proximate housing and main-street redevelopment.
- Biggest missing needs: sidewalk connectivity and safer walk-to-stop routes, healthcare access, local clinics, or medical shuttle service, accessible housing, ADA routes, and paratransit coordination.
- Signal: access score 64.44, mobility need 17.98, ACS population 20,775.

Source Context

- U.S. Census Bureau ACS 2024 5-year table-based Summary File: town population, income, poverty, zero-vehicle households, age 65+, disability, children under 18, housing cost burden, seasonal/vacant housing, commute mode, long commutes, work-from-home, and household internet access.
- MaineHousing, State of Maine Housing Production Needs Study: Maine needs more housing supply and better alignment between housing location, economic opportunity, and quality of life. https://www.mainehousing.org/docs/default-source/default-document-library/state-of-maine-housing-production-needs-study_full_final-v2.pdf
- MaineDOT, Maine 2024-2028 Locally Coordinated Plan: transit needs assessment focuses on the general public, individuals with disabilities, older adults, low-income people, and people without access to a vehicle. <https://www.maine.gov/dot/programs-services/transit>
- Maine DHHS, 2024-2029 State Health Improvement Plan: priority areas include healthy/stable housing and equitable access to care. <https://www.maine.gov/dhhs/mecdc/ship/>
- Maine DHHS/OADS, State Plan on Aging 2025-2028 and Age-Friendly State Plan: older adults and adults with disabilities need coordinated, livable community supports. <https://www.maine.gov/dhhs/oads/about-us/policy-planning>
- Maine Connectivity Authority, Digital Equity Plan: digital opportunity work targets older adults, veterans, low-income families, rural residents, people with disabilities, and minority populations. <https://www.maineconnectivity.org/digital-equity>
- Maine Department of Economic and Community Development, 2024 Economic Development Strategy Reset: workforce growth depends on supporting infrastructure such as housing, childcare, transportation, broadband, and local hubs. <https://www.maine.gov/decd/strategic-plan>
- Maine Climate Plan: future communities need lower-emission transportation choices, compact growth, climate-aware housing, and resilience. <https://www.maine.gov/climateplan/the-plan>
- HUD Location Affordability framing: housing decisions are stronger when transportation cost and access are evaluated together.